> airstrip. They clearly saw more danger from us than from the hijackers. The armed Talibs were constantly pointing their guns at us and not towards the hijackers.[186]

India lodged an official complaint with the International Civil Aviation Organisation that pressed the Taliban to prosecute the hijackers under the Hague Convention, and pressed the need to extradite the hijackers and the released militants to India.[187] Muttawakil still challenges this Indian view today. Moreover, in contrast to the popular Indian perception that the Taliban did not allow Indian commandos to storm the plane and position their soldiers in an offensive position, Muttawakil argues that the 'key actors [hijackers] wanted to take the plane to another destination, but we [Taliban] didn't allow that'.[188] There was tremendous mistrust between the hijackers and the Taliban as well. When Taliban sent workers inside the plane to clean the toilets, the hijackers became suspicious that the Taliban was planning to undertake a commando raid, and began to frantically search the cleaning staff.

The official Indian version of the Taliban's role in the hijacking incident is loaded with contradictions. If, as Indian policymakers argue, the Taliban indeed had sovereign jurisdiction over Kandahar and were expected to follow the rule of law and arrest the released militants and the hijackers, then why did India not open a political channel with the regime before the hijacking? If it were simply a question of sympathies, then a dialogue with the Taliban before the hijacking incident could have allowed New Delhi to ensure sensitivity towards its interests at Kandahar. Nothing of this sort was done, even if many thought it to be a prudent and pragmatic foreign policy approach. When the hijacking incident did happen, the Taliban's call for recognition came to be viewed more as blackmail than barter. In retrospect, even anti-Taliban partisans such as X concur that the Taliban did not like the hijacking. 'That [hijacking] is not *Pashtunwali*. But they [Taliban] were helpless. The pressure from the ISI was tremendous. They did have sovereign intent, but could not exercise it in practice'.[189] Sahay, for his part, though dismissing the question as hypothetical, rejects the idea that India would have gained much during the hijacking incident even if it had prior diplomatic relations with the Taliban—such was the ISI's influence on the Taliban.[190]

When asked how he expected India to react to Taliban's role in the hijacking, Muttawakil believes 'they [India] should be grateful, no doubt, but I don't think